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CHIEF LISTENING OFFICER

A relatively new role, nevertheless a growing one, a chief listening officer intervenes when social media managing just doesn't cut it anymore

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

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ustomer feedback, more often than not, is the most crucial element of running a successful company,

business or venture. A brand is usually defined by its marketing strategy and its ability to welcome feedback and follow up with an appropriate response or action. What a customer tells an acquaintance about

you often dictates the success or the eventual failure of your product or business. Chief Listening Officers (CLOs) are one rung higher than social media managers and it is their job to closely monitor social media platforms, news agencies as well as real-time conversations to be in the know about what is being said about their company or brand. This job essentially serves as a departure from the top-down, one-to-many view that most marketers are ingrained with. It brings up and attempts to combat a

fundamental challenge that many branding strategies don't address – what are customers saying about you, not just on social media, but also in customer-to-customer conversations in real-time?

WHAT DOES A CHIEF LISTENING OFFICER DO?

Ever listened to your friends talking for hours on end about their woes and thought to yourself that you're a really good listener? You could be a chief listening officer. Well, not really. However, the ability to listen is actually the most significant attribute a chief listening officer must possess. He ensures that the social media discussion around their brand or business actually reaches the board room and instils the importance of social media engagement in every business unit of the company. Dell and Kodak were the first large-scale companies to integrate chief listening positions in their respective companies in 2011.

Chief Listening Officers, alongside handling external communications, also work to build a fully engaged workplace. According to a 2016 Deloitte report, inadequate listening skills often hamper with the work environment in companies. Chief